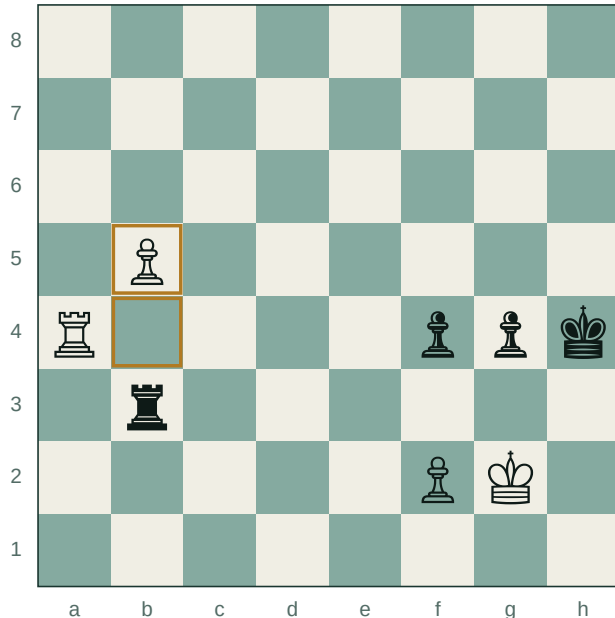


Rook-ending tactics: Black, move 41

Rook-ending tactics

Black to move



Previous move: 41.b5. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

41...f3+ 42. Kh2 Rb2 43. b6 Rxf2+

41...f3+ Check restricts White to 4 legal replies here. Recorded reply: **42.Kh2**.

42...Rb2 The rook moves from b3 to b2. Recorded reply: **43.b6**.

43...Rxf2+ Check restricts White to 2 legal replies here. The move also takes the pawn on f2.

At the end, nominal material is White 6 / Black 7 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, Black's balance changes by +1. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does Black's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer: +1**: the balance goes from +0 to +1. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

A routine rook placement can miss a skewer or promotion with check. Let concrete tactics override a guideline when they conflict.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

Rook endings combine pawn races with checks, cutoffs, and promotion tactics. Activity is vital, but the exact move order often decides whether a pawn can advance safely.

HOW TO LOOK

Check the kings' exposure, the rooks' checking distance, and the passed pawns. Calculate forcing checks before applying a general rook-ending rule.

The defending king is on g2. Geometrically undefended: rook on a4. Check for tactical protection.